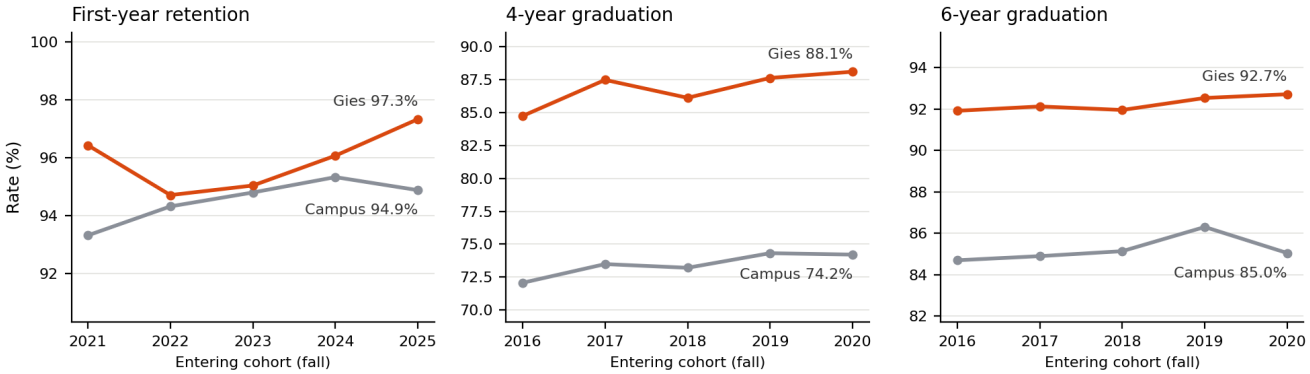
Gies students stay and graduate at the highest rates at Illinois: 92.7% finish within six years, 7.7 points above campus

Findings memo for a program director, November 2026

What the numbers show

- **Gies led the 11 entering units in four-year graduation.** For fall 2020 entrants, 88.1% graduated in four years, vs. 74.2% for all campus. That gap ranged from 12.7 to 14.0 points across five cohorts.
- **Gies retention was 2.68 points above the rest of campus.** Of fall 2025 entrants, 97.33% of Gies students returned (n = 787), vs. 94.65% of other entrants (n = 8,408). A two-proportion z-test gave a 95% confidence interval of 1.46 to 3.91 points. The chart uses all campus, which includes Gies: 94.88%, a 2.45-point gap.
- **Illinois as a whole graduates about what its first-year retention would predict.** Across 106 public research universities, each extra point of first-year retention goes with about 1.7 extra points of six-year graduation, and retention alone accounts for about 88% of the differences between schools. At 94% retention, Illinois would be expected to graduate 84.5%. It actually graduates 84.9%, just 0.4 points above, which is effectively on the line. *Source: IPEDS, 2023 data files.*



Gies vs. all campus by entering cohort; vertical scales differ by panel. DAIR measures first-year retention at the campus level: the share of first-time, full-time, degree-seeking undergraduates who return to UIUC the next fall, grouped by their college at entry.

What to keep in mind

- **This shows a pattern, not a cause.** Gies admits a strong entering class, so these numbers do not show how much of the lead comes from the college itself. Likewise, the link between retention and graduation is a comparison of schools. It does not promise that raising retention at one school would raise its graduation rate.
- **The two series cover different entering cohorts.** DAIR graduation uses fall 2016-2020 entrants; retention uses fall 2021-2025 entrants. The retention gap vs. all campus ranged from 0.2 to 3.1 points.

A next question

About 12% of Gies students who started in 2020 needed more than four years or left without a degree. With student-level records, the team could ask who those students are and when they went off track, for example whether first-year course outcomes or a change of major explain most of the delay.

Independent project using public data; not affiliated with Gies or DAIR. Sources: UIUC DAIR and NCES IPEDS, downloaded Nov 2, 2026.